HR Policies

Employment Terms, Compensation, Benefits, Performance and Separation Guidelines for Data Axle India

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Policy Owner: Head of People Operations, India (Priya Deshmukh)
Approved By: Managing Director, India (Rohan Kulkarni)
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Applies To: All employees on the payroll of Data Axle India Private Limited
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1. Introduction

This document describes the employment framework of Data Axle India Private Limited. It covers the employee lifecycle from joining to separation and describes the compensation and benefit programmes available to employees. Leave entitlements are governed by the Leave Policy (DA-IN-HR-003), paid holidays by the annual Holiday Calendar (DA-IN-HR-004), and conduct and working arrangements by the Company Policies (DA-IN-POL-001). All employee transactions referred to in this document are performed through the Axle Connect people portal.

2. Employment Categories

- **Regular employees** are engaged on the Company's payroll without a fixed end date and are eligible for all benefits described in this document.
- **Fixed-term employees** are engaged for a defined project or period not exceeding 24 months. They are eligible for statutory benefits and group medical insurance but not for the annual bonus or the learning allowance.
- **Interns** are engaged for 2 to 6 months under a stipend arrangement and are covered by the Company Policies but not by the leave, insurance or bonus provisions of this document.
- **Contractors and consultants** are engaged through a third-party agency or a services agreement and are governed by the terms of that agreement.

3. Joining and Onboarding

An offer becomes effective when the candidate accepts it in writing and the background verification is completed satisfactorily. Background verification covers identity, address, highest education, the last two employments and a criminal record check, and is conducted by an empanelled agency. On the date of joining, employees must present original documents including PAN, Aadhaar, educational certificates and the relieving letter from the previous employer. The relieving letter may be submitted within 30 days of joining where the previous employer has not yet issued it. New joiners complete a 3-day induction programme covering the Company's values, information security, the Code of Conduct and the POSH framework, and are assigned an onboarding buddy for their first 90 days.

4. Probation and Confirmation

All regular employees serve a probation period of 6 months from the date of joining. The reporting manager completes a probation review in Axle Connect during the fifth month. Where performance meets expectations, the employee is confirmed with effect from the date on which 6 months are completed and receives a confirmation letter. Where additional time is needed, probation may be extended once by up to 3 months with written reasons shared with the employee. An employee whose probation is neither confirmed nor extended in writing by the end of the sixth month is deemed confirmed. Employees who join at the level of Director or above are confirmed on joining.

5. Grades and Job Levels

Roles at Data Axle India are organised into seven job levels: Associate (L1), Analyst (L2), Senior Analyst (L3), Lead (L4), Manager (L5), Senior Manager (L6) and Director and above (L7). Job level determines the salary band, eligibility for certain benefits and the approval authority an employee holds. Promotions across levels are decided in the annual performance cycle and take effect on 1 April.

6. Working Hours, Shifts and Overtime

Standard working hours and the hybrid model are set out in Section 5 of the Company Policies. Employees who are rostered to a shift that ends after 10:00 PM or begins before 6:00 AM receive a shift allowance of INR 500 per shift worked, and the Company arranges door-to-door transport for such shifts. Shift rosters are published at least 2 weeks in advance. Employees at levels L1 to L3 who are required in writing to work more than 48 hours in a week are compensated in accordance with applicable law; employees at L4 and above are not eligible for overtime payment. Any employee required to work on a declared holiday is eligible for a compensatory day off under the conditions described in the Holiday Calendar.

7. Compensation

7.1 Salary Structure and Payment

Cost to Company (CTC) comprises basic salary, house rent allowance, special allowance, the Company's contribution to Provident Fund, and where applicable a variable performance bonus. Basic salary is fixed at 40 percent of fixed CTC for all levels. Salary for a month is credited to the employee's bank account on the last working day of that month, and the salary slip is available in Axle Connect on the same day. Salary for the month of joining or separation is paid on a pro-rata basis for the days worked.

7.2 Annual Increment and Variable Bonus

Salary revisions are made once a year and take effect on 1 April, based on the outcome of the annual performance review described in Section 9. Employees who join on or after 1 October are not eligible for a revision in the following April cycle and are considered in the subsequent cycle. Employees at level L4 and above have a variable performance bonus component that is paid in April for the preceding calendar year, subject to the employee being on the payroll and not serving notice on the date of payout.

7.3 Statutory Contributions

The Company contributes 12 percent of basic salary to the Employees' Provident Fund and deducts the matching employee contribution. Gratuity is paid in accordance with the Payment of Gratuity Act, 1972 to employees who complete 5 years of continuous service, calculated at 15 days of last drawn basic salary for every completed year. Professional tax is deducted as applicable in Maharashtra and Karnataka. Income tax is deducted at source based on the tax regime and declarations submitted by the employee in Axle Connect by 30 April each year, with investment proofs due by 31 January.

8. Employee Benefits

8.1 Group Medical Insurance

All regular and fixed-term employees are covered from the date of joining under a group medical insurance plan with a family floater sum insured of INR 5,00,000 covering the employee, spouse and up to two dependent children. Premium for this base cover is fully paid by the Company. Employees may add dependent parents or parents-in-law with a separate sum insured of INR 3,00,000 by paying the premium through salary deduction, and may increase the family floater to INR 10,00,000 by paying the incremental premium. Enrolment and changes are permitted within 30 days of joining or of a life event such as marriage or the birth of a child, and otherwise during the annual enrolment window in March. Maternity expenses are covered up to INR 75,000 per delivery.

8.2 Life and Accident Cover

The Company provides group term life insurance equal to 3 times annual fixed CTC and group personal accident insurance equal to 3 times annual fixed CTC, both at no cost to the employee. Employees must record their nominee details in Axle Connect within 30 days of joining.

8.3 Allowances and Reimbursements

- **Internet reimbursement:** INR 1,500 per month for all employees working under the hybrid model, paid with salary without bills against a one-time declaration.
- **Learning and development allowance:** up to INR 25,000 per calendar year for regular employees for external courses, certifications and conferences relevant to the role, approved in advance by the reporting manager. Unused allowance does not carry forward.
- **Home office set-up:** a one-time reimbursement of up to INR 10,000 for a chair, desk or monitor, available after confirmation of probation.
- **Mobile reimbursement:** INR 1,000 per month for employees at level L4 and above and for on-call support staff nominated by their department head.
- **Relocation:** employees who are asked by the Company to relocate between Pune and Bengaluru receive reimbursement of actual moving costs up to INR 75,000 and 15 days of temporary accommodation.

8.4 Employee Referral Programme

Employees who refer a candidate who is subsequently hired receive a referral bonus of INR 30,000 for engineering, data science and product roles and INR 15,000 for all other roles. The bonus is paid with the salary of the month after the referred employee completes 90 days of service. Employees in the People Operations team, hiring managers for the role and employees at level L6 and above are not eligible for referral bonus.

8.5 Employee Assistance and Wellbeing

All employees and their immediate family members have access to a confidential Employee Assistance Programme offering up to 6 counselling sessions per issue per year with qualified professionals, available by phone, video or in person in Pune and Bengaluru. The Company also reimburses an annual preventive health check-up of up to INR 3,000 for employees aged 35 and above.

9. Performance Management

The performance year runs from 1 January to 31 December. Goals are set in Axle Connect by 31 January, a mid-year check-in is completed in July, and the annual review is conducted in January and February of the following year. Employees are rated on a five-point scale: Exceptional, Exceeds Expectations, Meets Expectations, Partially Meets Expectations and Does Not Meet Expectations. Ratings are calibrated within each department before they are communicated. An employee rated Partially Meets Expectations or below is placed on a structured Performance Improvement Plan of 60 days with clearly defined goals and fortnightly reviews. Employees must have completed at least 6 months of service by 31 December to receive a rating for that year.

10. Learning, Internal Mobility and Promotions

Employees are expected to complete a minimum of 40 hours of learning each year, of which the mandatory compliance modules on information security, Code of Conduct and POSH awareness form a part. Internal job postings are open to employees who have completed at least 12 months in their current role and are not on a Performance Improvement Plan. Employees may apply for an internal posting without informing their current manager, but the manager is informed once the employee is shortlisted. Promotions are effective on 1 April and require a rating of Meets Expectations or higher in the most recent review.

11. Grievance Redressal

An employee with a workplace grievance should first raise it with the reporting manager. If unresolved within 7 working days, or if the grievance concerns the manager, the employee may escalate to the HRBP in writing. The HRBP acknowledges the grievance within 2 working days and communicates an outcome within 15 working days. A further appeal lies with the Head of People Operations, whose decision is final. Complaints of sexual harassment follow the POSH process described in the Company Policies, and ethical concerns may be raised through the Speak Up channel.

12. Separation from Employment

12.1 Resignation and Notice Period

An employee who wishes to resign must submit the resignation in Axle Connect; the notice period begins on the date of submission. The notice period is 30 days for employees on probation and 60 days for confirmed employees at all levels. The Company may, at its discretion, waive part of the notice period or allow the employee to buy out the unserved period at the rate of the employee's basic salary for the unserved days. Leave cannot be used to shorten the notice period except with the written agreement of the reporting manager and HRBP, and Earned Leave balance is not adjusted against the notice period. Employees serving notice are not eligible for increments, bonus payouts or referral bonus falling due during the notice period.

12.2 Termination by the Company

The Company may terminate employment by giving the same notice as applies to the employee, or salary in lieu of notice, in accordance with the employment contract. Termination for gross misconduct following the disciplinary process described in the Company Policies may be without notice. Employees who are made redundant because a role is eliminated receive, in addition to notice, severance of 15 days of fixed salary for every completed year of service, subject to a minimum of one month.

12.3 Exit Formalities and Final Settlement

On the last working day the employee must return the laptop, access card and all Company property and complete the knowledge transfer confirmed by the reporting manager. An exit interview is conducted by the HRBP during the final week. The full and final settlement, which includes salary up to the last working day, encashment of Earned Leave as per the Leave Policy, and recovery of any dues, is paid within 45 days of the last working day. The relieving letter and experience certificate are issued along with the settlement, and Form 16 is issued after the close of the financial year.

13. Amendments

The Company reserves the right to amend this document. Changes are approved by the Managing Director, India, published on Axle Connect and communicated by email at least 15 days before they take effect, unless required earlier by law. Queries may be addressed to people.india@data-axle.in.